The Pugilist

by Michael Dean



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SpeechGeek
248 Arlington Park Dr.
Hot Springs, AR 71901

Phone: 1-888-742-2028
Email: thegeek@speechgeek.com
Web: www.speechgeek.com
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THE PUGILIST. Mac? I let myself in like old times. Key still under the mat… Hope that's, okay?

No one here? Good.

God, that smell: leather, canvas, sweat, and blood—like my own personal church. I'm outta shape. Suppose that's what I get. In my day, heavy bags used to run away from my hands. Sometimes I swear I'd even see 'em flinch before I hit it. Bam. Bam. Bam!

"If it don't hurt, you ain't trying hard enough." That's what Mac'd say. 'Cuz these heal (*looks at his hands*); this don't (*points to his heart*).

Maybe that's why I'm here?

Maybe, I'm hoping it'll hurt less if I can put my pain somewhere I'm used to? Maybe I'm hoping I'll hear my dad or Mac coach me up off the canvas?

Maybe I'm just looking for one single thing that don't remind me of her?

The American Association of Neurological Surgeons says that 90 percent of boxers sustain brain injuries. Some of which have lasting neurological consequences such as headaches, mood disorders, loss of coordination and and increased suicide risk. While the disease is technically called encephalopathy, according to former heavyweight boxer Roy Jones Jr., "The real disease is obsession. We don't like getting hit, but we can't stomach getting forgotten." In his play, Michael Dean explores what happens after the bell rings. Suggesting that life is sometimes less about the punches we throw and more about the hits we take. In the end he shows us that when the lights go out, the real fight truly begins. The Pugilist by Michael Dean

THE PUGILIST. I ain't been in a ring in years. A lifetime.

I gave it up for Annie, and now it's the only thing I got left.

A lot of ghosts in this place, I tell ya. A lot of skeletons, too.

I don't know why I'm here, exactly. Just…well, this is where I grew up. It's home. And sometimes you need to talk to the open space a little. Not like a crazy nut job or something, but just letting your words out of your head. First time dad brought me here, he sat in this corner—probably on this stool—and made me spar with my older brother. He caught hell for it later from my ma, making an eight-year-old spar with a fourteen-year-old. But the thing was, I won. I was slow, but I had big hands and dad

knew I was gonna grow into ‘em, too. And I could take hits, man. You couldn't knock me down for nothin’.

Sure, I wasn't graceful. Dad said I moved like an elephant playing hopscotch, but that didn't matter. Movement only mattered if I didn't wanna get hit. I was never scared of getting hit. (*his nose starts to bleed*) Oh, crap.

Fricken nosebleeds.

Every other fricken day. It was one thing when I was getting hit all the time, but when I'm just sitting there? Nothing proud about blood that ain't earned.

I used to tell Annie it's ‘cuz of allergies.

No one ever heard of being dizzy ‘cuz of allergies, she'd say. And lately I see my hand shaking. But what do you expect, huh? I'm not the twenty-year-old bull she married anymore.

That guy…he was something. Training five hours a day, winning money left and right. I was on my way, boy. There ain’t a lot of people who can see themselves in the lights. Like truly. But I had the hands for it. I had the chin for it. I had the heart for it. I did.

Then…I met a girl. Ain’t that always the way?

Annie never liked me as a fighter. She wouldn't even go out with me at first. She said she didn't want to be with some...some brute.

And I never understood that. Maybe to her it looked like two animals in here, but it’s not. Good boxing is like, like poetry or something. It’s chess with fists. That’s why it’s called boxing not hitting. And when I would stand center ring and get my hand raised, I might be bloody, I might be tired, but I wasn’t thinking I just beat the hell outta someone. I was thinking. I proved I was stronger than my mind, that I could think my way around pain and exhaustion and some other guy’s fists. That’s not being dumb, I can tell ya that.

But you know, Annie wanted a nice guy. She said she wanted someone she could show off to her ma without black eyes and a bruised jaw.

So, I said okay. And the next day, I used some of my sister’s makeup on my face so you couldn't see the bruises, marched right over to Annie house, and knocked on the door. She answered and got ready to turn me down again, but instead, I asked to speak to her ma. Total head fake—said I wanted to

introduce myself, said I was trying to win over her daughter, and wanted her to know I was a good guy. Even brought flowers.

Classy shit, right?

Yeah, Annie had no choice but to fall in love with me after that. And if you think boxing is hard, trying going twelve rounds about the laundry with that woman. I lost every time we went toe to toe. And I loved it.

But she never watched me fight. Said she couldn't. Wouldn't watch someone hurt me. And I told her not watching hurt me worse.

She was always on me to quit. Give it up. Give it up for her. Give it up for my health.

When I started getting the headaches and forgetting which house was ours, she'd had enough. Said she'd leave me if I didn't leave it. So I gave it up. All of this. For her. I gave up who I was.

And for a guy ain't nobody knocked down, I gotta tell ya…that winded me.

I started drinking. A lot. What was I supposed to do? I got a wife who can't look at me, an empty house, and I got these two hands that feel heavier and heavier.

And then she starts in on me that I drink too much, that it's making the headaches worse and my forgetting. Asks me to give that up, too. Said she wanted me to remember my own kids' names. Turns out that wasn't a problem.

We tried to get pregnant. Couldn't. We tried to adopt. Couldn't. We wanted to foster kids. Couldn't. Nothing in the cards for Annie and me. Who would put kids in a house with a man who smashed skulls for a living? And I she never said it, but every time we fought, it was always there. Like a stink in the room—until one day we stopped fighting. Stopped talking altogether actually.

Then we're at this party. And some pretty boy comes up and grabs her for a dance, right there, in front of everyone. I say, "That's my wife." The guy looks me up and down like he's angling for something. I say do you even know who I am? And I hear someone say, "…who you used to be." And I swear to god, I think it's Annie. So I punched that guy so hard he was asleep before he hit the ground. And it felt good.

She said the booze changed me. It makes me mean. Angry. And I tell her ain't nothing changed about me but what she changed. Of course it makes me mean, anger is all I got left. You go from training five hours a day and fighting two times a month to what? This nobody? This dumb ox working at the same factory my dad died in? Mowing the grass at the high school on the weekends. Yeah, some stuff's gonna start to break down a little bit in here.

Then last night, in the car on the way home, she's yelling at me.

I'm a bastard.

I'm a drunk.

I'm a brute.

And I tell her "No, I'm a fighter. And you can't ask a fighter to not be a fighter. It don't work that way!"

She's telling me she doesn't want to live like this anymore.

My nose starts bleeding, and I can't see straight. I hear static in my ears, like, like the roar of a crowd after a hit. I see sparks and lights like flashbulbs, and it's like I'm back there

I hear her shouting and I think, just for a second, she's cheering me on when suddenly she screams, "Look out!"

And...they weren't spotlights. They were headlights.

By the time I come to, we're upside down and Annie…she's bleeding everywhere.

And I'm holding her, and she looks so small.

She says she's sorry, but I don't wanna hear it.

I think about how she ain't never wanna see me fight and I get it. She's fighting and I can't watch.

But she says she needs me to be stronger than that.

I tell her nothing—not a belt, not a bell, not a fist getting raised in the air—none of it ever felt as good as when she looked at me. Made me more than a fighter.

She died in the middle of a road. In my big heavy hands.

Then the whole universe stopped.

And I guess I could keep drinking, I guess I could go throw myself into some river. I wanted to. But instead I ended up here. Talking to no one.

'Cuz these heal *(holds up hands*), this don't (*points at heart*).